

OVERSTRETCHED LIVES

1 in 5 career women in metro India are found to bring office work home every day.

Nearly **80%** career women are assailed with guilt for not spending enough time at home.

5 women for 1 man found to be depressed in India, **40-60%** more in obesity patients.

Source: FICCI, Shell 2006

factors that could trap them into plus-sized bodies. "The prevailing misconception is that fat people are lazy, eat all the time, and lack self-discipline," says neuropsychiatrist Dr Rajesh Parikh at Mumbai's Jaslok Hospital and Research Centre. "This fat bias is believed to lead to guilt, shame, low self-esteem, depression, a vicious cycle of using food in response to negative emotions—boredom, sadness, anger, feelings of emptiness, work and family pressures—and more difficulty in keeping weight under control."

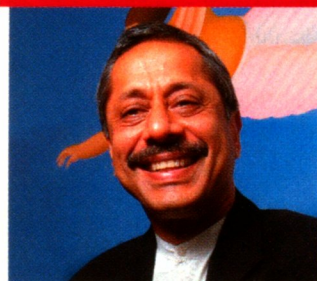
How does the "fat bias" work? Dietician Veena Aggarwal, head of R&D at VLCC Healthcare Ltd, Delhi, recounts the story of a mother whose 10-year-old son refused to let her attend the parent-teacher meeting at school. "I don't want anyone to see you. They'll tease me to death," shouted the boy tearfully when taken to task by the parents. In a country where, until recently, fat

was linked unabashedly with prosperity, there's a new intolerance for weight gain. "You are not good enough, is the message family and society send to overweight women," Aggarwal points out. It only takes a modest weight gain for a woman to experience weight discrimination, but men can gain far more weight before experiencing a similar bias, says a new report from Yale University, published last month in the *International Journal of Obesity* (10).

That's exactly what has been plaguing the Indian courts since 2006, when Indian Airlines decided to ground hostesses for being "too fat to fly". The grounded women blamed the airline's changing vision of Indian feminine ideal—abandoning the buxom prototype in favour of a westernised, skinny model—to compete with private carriers who favour leggy hostesses in high heels and skimpy skirts. The Yale study found that women begin to experience a noticeable weight bias—such as problems at work or difficulty in personal relationships—when they reach a body mass index (BMI) of 27. For a 5-ft-5-inch woman, discrimination starts once she reaches a weight of 73 kg. A 5-ft-9-inch man needs to bloat up to 107 kg to face the fat bias.

Overstretched waistlines also reflect overstretched lives. As India's "new worldly women" rejig their lives, flood into higher education and the job market, marry later, have fewer children, balance home and work, they also take on too much load. At the workplace, they are found to be as, if not more, committed than men, reports a 2006 study by the Shell Group on 12,000 young professionals. And one in five women brings office work home everyday. Yet not much has changed on the home front. Women are still expected to be Ms Perfect—provide *garam khana*, monitor children's studies and after-school activities, stand in queue to pay bills, organise family vacations, keep the home clean, do bank work and take care of pets. "Most women who work have a double shift," says Dr Firuza Parikh, infertility specialist at Jaslok. "They usually don't get their quota of

43% women executives, compared to 24% men, found to be obese in Delhi



◀ **DR NARESH TREHAN, CARDIOLOGIST**
Doesn't accept the conventional logic that women sit around and eat junk food. By that logic, he feels, men should bloat up more.

"Career women, juggling work and home, can't be called sitting ducks."



◀ **SHIVALI M. CHOUHAN, CIVIL SERVANT**
Deeply resented being judged by body image and societal fat bias. To prove a point, she decided to ignore looks and excel in all else.

"I am determined not to be bogged down by negative bias."